



DEFENCE

EYES OVER THE OCEAN

Andaman & Nicobar is a vantage point to monitor the Indian Ocean Region and the Malacca Strait, to counter Chinese posturing and is a lauchpad towards the Indo-Pacific

THE PROSPECTS

- Several naval bases and air stations of India's tri-service Andaman and Nicobar Command are undergoing infrastructure upgrades
- The planned civil-military airport near Galathea Bay will increase rapid deployment, maritime domain awareness
- The naval air station in Campbell Bay, INS Baaz, is being upgraded and its runway expanded to support aircraft with longer ranges
- Great Nicobar can become a major logistics node for India's Quad partners

THE DOUBTS

- With INS Baaz upgraded, analysts question the need for another military/ civilian airport in Great Nicobar
- With security/ strategic aspects deemed so important, how much sense does it make to have a huge transhipment terminal in Great Nicobar?

gal and deliberative processes". Rahul Gandhi had earlier flagged alleged regulatory violations in the project and its impact on tribal communities. But the most sustained critique has come from former environment minister Jairam Ramesh, who has described the project as an "environmental and humanitarian disaster" and engaged in an extended exchange on the issue with Yadav in August 2024. Ramesh called the recent NGT verdict deeply disappointing, taking to X to remark: "There is clear evidence that the project will have disastrous ecological impacts. The conditions for its clearance that the NGT draws reference to will do little to deal with these long-term consequences.



"The project's strategic importance lies in the ability of island-based forces to monitor and, if required, interdict trade and energy shipping lanes traversing the Bay of Bengal"

ADMIRAL ARUN PRAKASH
Former Chief of the Naval Staff

The matter is, however, still under argument in the Calcutta High Court that now is the only beacon of hope."

THE COMMERCIAL ADVANTAGE

Despite the raft of concerns, the Modi government remains firmly committed to the project. Ministry officials argue that, commercially, the proposed Galathea Bay International Container Transhipment Terminal (ICTT) aims to tap the shipping business along the East-West shipping corridor, given its proximity to the Strait of Malacca. This deepwater port, envisioned with an eventual capacity of 16 million TEUs (twenty-foot equivalent units), would handle containerised cargo from large intercontinental vessels and transfer it to smaller feeder vessels serving ports across the Bay of Bengal, Andaman Sea and Arabian Sea. The first phase, planned as a 20-metre natural-draft deepwater site, has an estimated cost of Rs 18,000 crore and is expected to be operational by 2028. This would be only the second such facility in India after the Vizhinjam International Seaport Thiruvananthapuram, which was inaugurated in May last year.